

THE FUTURE OF CARDIFF

What we need to do, what it takes, and how you can help.

Where We Stand

Cardiff has been a town since 1900. But our government has gone quiet. No meetings have been held in years. No one is currently serving as mayor, council, or clerk.

Without a working government, we cannot fix our roads, pass ordinances, apply for grants, or handle the problems that affect all of us. Cardiff still exists on paper, but it needs people to bring it back to life.

This handout explains what it would take to restart our town, who we need, and what the law asks of the people who step up.

Why This Matters Right Now

Cardiff has real problems that only a working town government can solve:

- **Lynn Crossing Road is in terrible shape.** It is washed out in places and full of downed trees from recent storms. When trains block the crossing (which is happening more and more), Lynns Crossing is the only way out. Going “over the hill” adds 10 minutes to get anywhere.
 - **We have no say over what happens here.** Without a government, we cannot pass ordinances to manage truck traffic, apply for road funding, or speak with a voice that the county or state will listen to.
 - **There is grant money available.** The Rebuild Alabama Act gives out \$15 million a year to fix local roads. Some of that money requires no local match at all — up to \$250,000 per project. But only a working municipality can apply.
 - **Our woods are a wildfire risk.** Years of downed trees and brush have piled up. A working government can coordinate with state forestry and emergency management.
 - **Illegal dumping and stray animals.** Without a local government, there is no enforcement of anti-dumping laws. State agencies like ADEM will coordinate with a town government, but they rarely act on their own in a dormant municipality. A reinstated town can also enter into a service agreement with Jefferson County Animal Control.
 - **If we do nothing, Cardiff may dissolve.** A town that stays dormant long enough can lose its charter. If that happens, we go into unincorporated Jefferson County with no local representation at all.
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How We Restart

We cannot just hold a meeting and start governing. Alabama law has a specific process for restarting a dormant town. It goes through the Jefferson County Probate Court.

The law that covers this: Alabama Code § 11-41-7 — “Reinstatement of corporate organization of dormant municipalities.”

The Steps

- A majority of Cardiff’s **taxpayers** sign a petition asking the Probate Judge to reinstate the town’s government. Under Alabama law, “taxpayers” generally means the assessed property owners on the Jefferson County ad valorem tax rolls — not just residents. This includes non-resident property owners within the town limits.
- The petition goes to the Jefferson County Probate Court. The Probate Judge reviews it and, if everything checks out, issues an official court order that reinstates Cardiff’s government.
- The Probate Judge **appoints** a mayor and council members. These first officials are not elected — they are appointed by the judge as part of the reinstatement order.
- The appointed officials take their oaths of office and get to work. The council then elects a clerk at its first meeting.
- The appointed officials serve until the next regular municipal election, when voters choose their replacements. For Cardiff, a Class 8 municipality, the next municipal election cycle falls in 2028.

Things We Still Need to Find Out

The law does not spell out every detail. Before we file a petition, we need answers to these questions from the Probate Court and the Alabama League of Municipalities:

- How many signatures do we need exactly? We need a majority of assessed property owners — but we need the official tax roll from the Jefferson County Tax Assessor to get a precise number.
- Is there a standard petition form, or do we write our own?
- Will the Probate Judge accept recommendations on who to appoint?
- Are there any issues with the 1900 town boundaries that need to be resolved before filing?

What Positions We Need

Cardiff needs three things: a mayor, council members, and a clerk. That is it.

Position	How Filled	What They Do
Mayor	Appointed by Probate Judge	Runs the meetings. Signs documents. Oversees the budget. Arranges the annual audit.
Council (3–5 seats)	Appointed by Probate Judge	Votes on ordinances and the budget. Elects the clerk. Sets town policy. In a town our size, the mayor votes too.
Clerk	Elected by the council	Takes the meeting minutes. Keeps the town records. Handles paperwork. This is the most hands-on job.

Quorum: A quorum is the minimum number of people who have to be present to do business. It is a majority of the filled seats. If we have five council members, at least three have to be there. If we have three council members, at least two have to be there.

Pay: The council sets pay by ordinance. It can be zero. Cardiff has not traditionally paid its officials. The new council could decide to cover expenses for the mayor and clerk if the budget allows. That is a decision for the council to make once we know what the town's finances look like.

Clerk Bond: Alabama law requires the clerk to get a surety bond before being sworn in. The council sets the amount. For a town our size, the cost is small — typically around \$100 a year for limits under \$50,000 — and the town can pay for it.

What the Law Requires of Everyone Who Serves

If you serve in any of these positions, Alabama law requires a few things from you. None of this is complicated, but you should know about it before you raise your hand.

Requirement	What It Means
Oath of Office	You take an oath before you start. A notary or the Probate Judge can give it.
Statement of Economic Interests	Once a year (by April 30), you fill out a form online at seiform.alabama.gov . It takes about 15 to 30 minutes. It is a public record. Required of every municipal official in Alabama, no matter how small the town. See details below.
Ethics Training	Within 120 days of being sworn in, you complete ethics training online. It is free.
Annual Training	Starting in 2025, all mayors and council members must complete 10 hours of training per year (40 hours over a 4-year term). Twenty of those hours must be core classes through the Alabama League of Municipalities. Training is available online. The town is required by law to reimburse reasonable training expenses.
Monthly Meeting	Towns our size are required to meet at least once a month.

About the Economic Interests Form

This form has stopped people from serving before. Here is what it actually asks for:

- Your name, address, and employer
- The names of your spouse, children, parents, and siblings (names only — not their finances)
- Where you own property (county and state — not address or value)
- Any sources of income over \$1,000 for you and your spouse
- Any business you have with the government

You fill it out online at **seiform.alabama.gov**. If you do not file it, there is a fine of up to \$10 a day, capped at \$1,000 a year. This is the law for every elected or appointed official in Alabama, even in a town of 52 people with no budget.

Background Checks

Alabama does not require background checks for town officials. The main rule is that you have to be a registered voter in Cardiff. If someone has been convicted of a “crime of moral turpitude” — which under Alabama law is a specific list including theft, fraud, and violent offenses — they lose the right to vote, which means they cannot serve.

If you have a minor record but are still a registered voter, you are eligible. The new council could decide to add its own rules later, but the state does not require it.

The Rebuild Alabama Act — Why It Matters

The Rebuild Alabama Act is one of the strongest reasons to restart our government. Here is what is available for Fiscal Year 2026:

- **\$15 million total program funding** for local projects.
- **\$10 million requires zero local match** — meaning Cardiff would not have to put up any of its own money.
- **Up to \$250,000 per project** with no match required. That is enough for major road and drainage repairs.
- **Only a functioning municipality can apply.** Cardiff is ineligible until we are reinstated.

The work has to go through competitive bidding, and projects have to move forward within one year of the award. But for a town with no budget, this is real money for real problems.

What if We Do Not Restart?

Restarting is our best option, but it is not the only one. Here are the other paths:

Consolidate with Another Town

Alabama law allows two neighboring towns to merge. Brookside is the closest option. Both towns would have to agree, and voters in the town being absorbed would have to approve it in an election. Cardiff would need to be reinstated first before it could negotiate any terms.

Dissolve

If nobody steps up, Cardiff’s charter could eventually be forfeited. Under Alabama Code § 11-41-24, the Jefferson County Commission or five qualified voters in the county could petition the Probate Judge to declare the charter forfeited. Cardiff would become unincorporated Jefferson County. We would lose any local say we have. No one would be looking out for Cardiff specifically. This is what happens if we do nothing.

What We Need from You

We need people willing to serve and people willing to sign. Here is what helps:

- **Volunteer to serve.** We need a mayor, up to 5 council members, and a clerk. You do not need any special experience. You need to live in Cardiff, be a registered voter, and be willing to show up.
- **Sign the petition.** When the petition is ready, we will need a majority of Cardiff's assessed property owners to sign it. The more people who sign, the stronger our case to the Probate Judge.
- **Spread the word.** Talk to your neighbors. Share this handout. The more people who know about this, the better our chances.
- **Show up to meetings.** Once we are up and running, a town this small needs every voice it can get.

Our Next Steps

- Get the official taxpayer list from the **Jefferson County Tax Assessor** so we know exactly how many signatures we need.
- Call the **Alabama League of Municipalities** for legal guidance on the reinstatement process. Phone: (334) 262-2566.
- Contact the **Jefferson County Probate Court** to understand the petition requirements. Judge Yashiba Blanchard, (205) 325-5203.
- Draft and circulate the petition.
- File the petition with the Probate Court.
- Once the judge reinstates us and appoints officials — hold our first meeting.

Cardiff has been here since 1900. Whether it stays depends on us.

cardiffalabama.info

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This handout is not legal advice. Last updated April 2026.